Campus Networking

Major corporations are deploying WiFi networks across their corporate campuses to provide ubiquitous connectivity for their employees; universities are doing the same for their students and faculty. Unlike the consumer access points, these deployments typically have beefed up security and reliability. WiFi is one of the few remaining growth areas in the depressed data networking sector, a fact not lost on vendors such as Cisco. Leading information technology services companies such as IBM have developed expertise integrating and installing these corporate networks.

Industrial Applications

Manufacturers such as Boeing are using WiFi to network their factories and warehouses. Such environments don't lend themselves to wired connections. The ability to track inventory and access internal corporate documents from anywhere can generate substantial cost savings and efficiency benefits for these companies, who take advantage of the maturity and low cost of WiFi equipment thanks to its consumer applications.

Virtual ISPs

Several companies are linking together the scattered hotspots through roaming arrangements, creating nationwide virtual networks. Examples include Boingo, Joltage, Wayport, and NetNearU. Some of these companies encourage individuals and small businesses to establish new access points, offering to share revenues from wireless access with them. A New York Times report earlier this year stated that several major technology and communications companies including Intel, Microsoft and Cingular Wireless were evaluating creating a nationwide WiFi roaming network, known as Project Rainbow. All this activity has taken place in an already-crowded unlicensed band, without any protection against interference from other users. WiFi is an existence proof for the validity of the open spectrum argument.